

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Metra shrouds results of \$1.5M investigation

Rail agency refuses to release reports produced by internal probe of its Police Department

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

Metra hired a team of outside lawyers, who worked more than seven months, to conduct an internal investigation that cost the agency nearly \$1.57 million.

But the outcome of the 2023

investigation remains shrouded, after the rail agency refused to make public reports or memos produced by the law firm, McGuireWoods.

The investigation stemmed from anonymous complaints made to Metra about the agency's Police Department, and bills from the

attorneys hint at the scope of the work: McGuireWoods undertook analysis related to an "investigation of potential disparate treatment." Also included among 130 pages of attorneys bills was reference to "EEO" incidents and complaints, according to documents obtained by the Tribune through a Freedom of Information Act request.

Still, Metra's failure to publicize information about the outcome of the investigation — and the agen-

cy's decision to rely on an outside law firm to investigate its Police Department in the first place — raises questions about Metra's motives, government transparency advocates said.

"I think it's safe to say that given the scope and cost of this investigation, given the widespread use of Metra and how many people rely on it every single day, there is a strong public interest in knowing what they found," said Jack

Bentley, executive director of the Elmhurst-based Citizen Advocacy Center. "And I think we should start by encouraging Metra to rethink their position."

The internal investigation was previously reported by the Daily Herald, but the details remain unclear. Metra denied a Tribune public records request for copies of the report, citing attorney-client

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A rose rests at the base of a plaque for Nicolás Toledo at a temporary memorial outside Highland Park City Hall on Tuesday. The memorial honors the victims of a July 4, 2022, shooting. Toledo and six other people were killed, and 48 people were injured. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

'We saw evil that day'

Highland Park mass shooting survivors hope for justice, resolution as trial begins

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

The doctor will never forget the horror he witnessed during the 2022 Highland Park Independence Day parade mass shooting.

As gunshots rained down and throngs of terrified parade-goers ran in all directions, Dr. David Baum rushed to render aid. A couple were lying in a pool of blood. Family members frantically scooped up critically injured loved ones, carrying them away. The back of one man's head was blown off; his son was by his side, screaming into the crowd "help him" over and over again, recalled Baum, who was attending the parade.

"I saw the kind of wounds that people only describe as wounds seen in war," he said.

The Highland Park obstetrician doesn't know if there can be any justice after such a heinous act, which left seven dead, four dozen



People embrace during a vigil at Central and St. Johns avenues in Highland Park on July 5, 2022, a day after the mass shooting.

injured and an entire community terrorized and upended.

But Baum said he still longs to see the shooter held accountable by the law and locked up for life.

"For those people who died and

their families...they need it far more than me," he added.

More than two years after that horrific holiday, the suspect's trial is scheduled to begin with jury selection Monday at the Lake

County Courthouse. Alleged gunman Robert Crimo III faces more than 100 charges, including 21 counts of first-degree murder — three for each person who lost their life while attending the parade. If convicted of first-degree murder, he could be sentenced to life in prison without parole.

The trial is expected to be a particularly emotional one: Lake County prosecutors have said they intend to call as witnesses many of the 48 people who were wounded on July 4, 2022, when authorities say Crimo fired an AR-15-style assault rifle from a rooftop at the crowd along the parade route below.

Judge Victoria Rossetti ruled Thursday that victim witnesses can be in the courtroom during the trial, agreeing with prosecutors that their testimony wouldn't be materially affected by hearing the testimony of others.

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Zelenskyy says he'd step down for peace

As Russia's invasion reaches 3-year mark, Ukraine still stands

By Constant Méheut
The New York Times

KYIV, Ukraine — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Sunday that he is willing to step down if it meant peace in Ukraine, which on Monday marks three years since Russia invaded. His remark came days after President Donald Trump questioned his legitimacy and called him a "dictator without elections," echoing a Kremlin talking point.

At the same time, Zelenskyy continued to push back against Trump's insistence that he sign a minerals deal that Ukraine says is unpalatable. And he announced a meeting Monday of more than 30 countries in person or online as a kind of coalition of support for Ukraine's war effort.

It was not immediately clear whether Zelenskyy had seriously considered the option of stepping down or was merely responding to the latest jabs from Washington and Moscow. He said he could trade his departure for Ukraine's entry into NATO — a highly unlikely scenario, given Trump's opposition to allowing Ukraine into the military alliance.

"If peace for Ukraine requires me to step down, I'm ready," Zelenskyy said during a news conference Sunday, the eve of the third anniversary of Russia's invasion. "Another scenario — I could trade my position for NATO membership, if that's what it takes."

For now, Zelenskyy said, Ukraine and the United States remain locked in negotiations over a deal to trade Ukraine's minerals and other natural resources for U.S. aid.

Zelenskyy said he is still not ready to sign the United States' latest proposal, which would require Ukraine to pay the United States \$500 billion using revenues from its natural resources.

"I am not signing something that 10 generations of

Turn to Ukraine, Page 10

Cook County moves to change how it offloads delinquent taxes

Bill would allow those who lose property to recoup some value

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Cook County homeowners who lose their properties because of unpaid property taxes would be in line for a share of the resale price under a proposed change to state law to prevent what critics call "equity theft."

The bill, backed by county Treasurer Maria Pappas, calls for an open auction after a tax sale, through which a property owner could recoup some of its value. As it stands today, people who buy a home's unpaid taxes can eventually get the deed simply by paying late property taxes and fees, effectively pocketing the home's value.

Pappas may not have much choice but to seek changes. The Supreme Court recently sided with a Minnesota homeowner

who lost her condo because of overdue taxes. Her attorneys successfully argued that systems similar to Cook County's rob delinquent homeowners of equity. A similar local lawsuit from Cook County property owners is seeking class-action status.

"We want to find a way to resolve this in the General Assembly this year," said state Rep. Will Guzzardi, D-Chicago,

Turn to Taxes, Page 5



ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Town hall meeting targets extremism

Mayor Brandon Johnson's new task force for digging into extremism among city employees was met with fierce demands for fast, decisive action at a town hall meeting Sunday. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

